

WORKING THE SEA · ARNELA ESTUARY

People of the low tide

Twice a day the water drains out of the estuary and leaves a kilometre of sand behind. That is when the shellfish gatherers work; on the quay, the net menders sew up what the sea tore the night before. We spent a week in October with five trades that keep the tide's time.

Arnela has fourteen hundred people, a harbour with eleven inshore boats and an estuary that all but empties at low water. From the coast road you can see the whole village: white houses packed onto the hillside, the church at the top and, at the bottom, the fish market under its corrugated roof. What you cannot see from up there is the timetable. Nobody in Arnela arranges to meet at five or at six; they meet "at half tide" or "when it's out", and the tide table the fishermen's guild pins up each month beside the market door counts for more than any clock.

This week low water falls at a quarter past seven in the morning and half past seven in the evening. An hour before, the sand is already full of people.

On foot at low water

Carmen Lago started gathering shellfish at fourteen, alongside her mother, and she is sixty-one now. She works with a long-handled rake, a bucket and a mesh basket, always on the same plot of the estuary, the one the guild assigns each season to her group of nine women (**fig. 1**). She drags the rake against the current, crouches, sorts out by hand the cockles that fall short of the minimum size and puts them back in the hole they came from.

"The small ones stay," she says. "Take them today and there's nothing in March."

Each gatherer may take a fixed daily quota per species, which the guild reviews according to the state of the beds. In October



Figure 1. Carmen Lago sorts cockles on her plot of the estuary at low water.

Carmen's is three kilos of carpet-shell clams and eight of cockles. Anything over the quota goes back into the sand. At nine, as the water starts to cover the first pools, the group climbs the slope to the market with their buckets. There the catch is washed, weighed gatherer by gatherer and graded by size before the auction at eleven.

The work does not end on the sand. Two days a week the group "sows": they move young clams from the patches where they crowd together to the ones that have emptied, and clear the sand of weed and of the starfish that eat the young. Nobody is paid for those hours. "It's like watering the vegetable patch," says Carmen, who still remembers the winters when there was nothing to take.

The eleven o'clock auction

Arnela's fish market is a long shed with a concrete floor that is never dry. By a quarter to eleven the morning's crates are lined up on the belt: the gatherers' shellfish, sorted by species and size, and the inshore boats' fish, line-caught hake, horse mackerel, the odd turbot. Each crate carries a label with its weight, its zone and the name of whoever brought it in.

The auction runs downwards. An electronic board starts at a high price and drops ten cents at a time; the first buyer to press a handset takes the crate at that price. Three wholesalers from the district buy here, two restaurants in the village and a processing plant that packs clams for the whole province. In October a kilo of carpet-shell clams fetches around twenty-six euros and a kilo of cockles about seven. On a good morning two tonnes are sold in forty minutes.

Marisa Couto has kept the market's books for nineteen years. She notes every sale on a sheet, with the buyer and the price, and at the end of the month pays out each gatherer's and each boat's share, less the guild's commission. "We used to shout," she remembers. "Now all you hear is the board beeping, and by one o'clock the floor's been hosed down."

The net menders on the quay

At the end of the quay, beside the market's stacked crates, Rosa Doval works on a low stool with a green net spread around her like a rug (**fig. 2**). The purse seiners came in before dawn with sardines and with three torn panels; a rock split one of them, and the hole is big enough for a person to climb through.

Rosa sews with a plastic needle as long as her hand, loaded with twine, and a small wooden gauge that sets the size of each mesh. She trims the frayed edges back to whole meshes, counts the ones missing and knots the patch in mesh by mesh. A large hole takes her a morning. A new panel, two to three hundred metres of net, takes four women most of a month.

Seven net menders are left in Arnela. They organised twelve years ago, when the boat owners began sending their nets to workshops inland, and now they are paid by the hour rather than by the patch. The youngest is twenty-eight and learned on a course run by the guild; the oldest is eighty-one and only sews on fine days. Rosa prefers the quay to the shed the council lent them: "With the net in the sun you see the holes better, and I hear what every boat has brought in."

The last boatyard on the shore

At the head of the cove, where the coastal path turns into a dirt track, a timber shed with its doors open smells of resin and fresh-cut pine. It is Manuel Barreiro's boatyard, the last of the five the estuary once had. Manuel is seventy-four and works with his nephew on a six-metre gamela, a flat-bottomed boat once used for gathering shellfish afloat (**fig. 3**).

The hull has been on the slipway since August. First comes the keel, then the oak frames, bent over a fire, and last the pine planks of the skin, fixed one by one with copper nails. Manuel works without drawings. He takes the shapes from plywood templates he inherited from his father, which hang on the back wall, each with the name of the boat it was made for pencilled on it.



Figure 2. Rosa Doval mends a purse-seine panel on the quay.



Figure 3. Manuel Barreiro planes the planking of the gamela.



Figure 4. Arnela point: the lighthouse and the coastal path.

In the eighties the yard launched fifteen boats a year. Now it builds two or three, nearly always for rowing clubs or for families who want their grandfather's boat back. This gamela was ordered by the residents' association, which wants to race it in the summer regattas in the village colours. Manuel reckons it will be in the water by April, if the winter lets him work with the doors open.

The lighthouse and the path

From the boatyard the path climbs through gorse to Arnela point, where a white lighthouse with a red lantern marks the mouth of the estuary (**fig. 4**). It was automated in 1993 and nobody has lived in the keeper's house since, but Xosé Pazos, who looked after it for twenty-two years, still walks up twice a week to check the batteries and note the wind and the state of the sea in an exercise book.

The trail that leads there is part of an eleven-kilometre route around the whole estuary, beach to beach, which the district waymarked three years ago with wooden posts and yellow arrows. In October few walkers pass: a group of pensioners, couples with rucksacks and, at weekends, runners heading down to the harbour. If they ask, Pazos shows them the way down to Cantal cove without slipping on the wet rock.

In bad weather the waves break on the point and run up the rocks to the foot of the tower. Pazos keeps a photograph from 1987 in which the water reaches the door. That winter he spent three days unable to get down to the village, with the radio, a box of tins and the exercise book.

The Sunday cauldron

On Sundays the covered market opens at nine, and by ten there is a queue at Lucía Fraga's stall. Lucía cooks octopus the way her mother did, in an eighty-litre copper cauldron over a wood fire: she "scares" it by dipping it in the boiling water three times so the skin stays on, lets it cook for about twenty minutes and lifts it out on a hook when the tip of a tentacle gives under the fork.



Figure 5. Lucía Fraga lifts an octopus out of the copper cauldron.

She cuts it with scissors onto wooden plates, adds coarse salt, sweet and hot paprika in equal parts and a stream of olive oil, and serves it with cachelos, potatoes boiled in the same water. A plate costs twelve euros. On summer Sundays Lucía cooks thirty octopuses; in October, fourteen or fifteen, bought on Friday at the market from the harbour's own pot boats.

By two in the afternoon the tide is low again. On the sand the first buckets are out and, on the quay, a net lies drying in the sun.

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